

Japan wants IAA deal for cars

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【要点】

- ・日本政府はEU加盟国に対し、産業加速化法（IAA）の下で日本車を「メイド・イン・ヨーロッパ」と分類する二国間協定の締結を働きかけている。
- ・フランスはEU域内生産の電動車のみに公的資金を提供すべきと主張しており、自動車サプライヤーから圧力を受けている一方、イタリアとDG TRADEは日本を信頼できるパートナーとして扱う姿勢を示している。
- ・ホンダのヨーロッパ統括責任者は、フランスとイタリアの代表者と会談してIAAについてロビー活動を行い、日本大使がイタリア訪問を予定している。
- ・ホンダはヨーロッパの競争の激しい市場に対応するため、従来の大量生産車からより独自性のある「軽自動車」などの小型車への戦略転換を進めている。

【メール原文】

Presented by BMW Group By MARTINA SAPIO with JORDYN DAHL SNEAK PEEK —The Japanese government is lobbying EU member countries to score a bilateral deal

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SNEAK PEEK

—The Japanese government is lobbying EU member countries to score a bilateral deal that would classify its cars as “Made in Europe” under the Industrial Accelerator Act.

— Large parts of the Netherlands’ rail network were severely disrupted after materials were placed on tracks at at least 20 locations, in what a senior rail industry official called a “deliberate sabotage.”

— For a larger merchant ship, bypassing the Red Sea can add costs in the mid-six-figure range per voyage, the German Shipowners’ Association told POLITICO.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility. Air traffic controllers at Charleroi airport are going on strike starting this evening after negotiations fell apart over a labor dispute. The strike will last from 10 p.m. until 8 a.m. Thursday, and could even go on until Oct. 10.

Tips to jdahl@politico.eu , tlecca@politico.eu and msapio@politico.eu . Follow us @tommylecca , @jordyndahl and @martsapio .

DRIVING THE DAY

JAPAN WANTS BILATERAL AGREEMENT ON IAA: Tokyo is continuing to push the European Commission for a bilateral agreement on the Industrial Accelerator Act, arguing Japan should be treated as a trusted partner on equal footing with European countries. The consensus from meetings with Commission officials and member countries is that no one wants the IAA to undermine broader EU-Japan relations, Hans De Jaeger, Honda's head of Europe, told Jordyn in an exclusive interview Tuesday. But the road ahead won't be easy.

Lobbying Council: France wants public funding for all-electric vehicles to be available only to those produced in the 27 EU member countries. The French government is under pressure from their automotive suppliers, which want a stricter definition of which countries qualify as "Made in Europe," De Jaeger said. Consequently, the Belgian native who's also the first non-Japanese individual to head a region for the automaker, met with French and Italian representatives during his visit to Brussels to lobby the Commission and Council on the IAA.

Divided opinions: Rome and DG TRADE, however, are more of the mindset that "Japan is a trusted partner, and we want to keep that kind of cooperation," De Jaeger said. The Japanese ambassador to the EU plans to visit Italy to continue lobbying for its companies to be considered "Made in Europe." "It's quite high on the agenda," De Jaeger said.

Europe is the "most competitive, difficult market," De Jaeger said, and the Japanese automaker is adjusting accordingly. Honda's is shifting its European strategy from producing the mass volume cars they're known for (think models like the Accord), toward making "more unique" models like the "kei cars" — these are much smaller than a standard vehicle and can better navigate narrow roads and small parking spaces — that are popular in Japan, the executive said. Honda has already launched a similar model in the U.K.

Scaling problems: These models are well within the Commission's desired range for the small, affordable electric vehicles it wants on the market. But only automakers that produce them in the EU would be eligible to receive supercredits toward their emission targets. Honda doesn't have any European automotive manufacturing, and its small sales numbers don't give it the scale to justify local production, De Jaeger said.

Honda currently sells around 90,000 vehicles across Europe each year and wants to increase that figure to 120,000, he added. By comparison, fellow Japanese automaker Toyota sells close to 1.2 million each year .

Never say never: Honda's European headquarters is in the U.K., but it closed down its one production facility because of low volumes. The automaker isn't opposed to creating production facilities in the EU, but "the business case has to be very, very solid," De Jaeger said.

More averaging, please: Like its European peers, Honda is also lobbying the Commission for more flexibilities in the emission targets. In the December 2025 automotive package, the Commission proposed averaging the emissions over three years — from 2030 to 2032 — rather than measuring them separately each year. Honda, among others, wants that averaging to be extended to five years.

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RAIL

DUTCH RAIL NETWORK HIT BY SABOTAGE: Large parts of the Netherlands' rail network were severely disrupted Tuesday morning after materials were deliberately placed on tracks at at least 20 locations, in what a senior rail industry official called a "deliberate sabotage."

What happened: The official told Martina the incidents began at around 5:30 a.m. and were concentrated around Zwolle, as well as the Utrecht-Gouda and Amersfoort-Apeldoorn-Deventer corridors, with knock-on effects across the wider Dutch network. Unknown persons placed materials — including metal pipes — on the tracks and in some cases attached them directly to the rails.

How it worked: The objects interfered with the track circuits used to detect whether a section of railway is occupied by a train. That caused the system to register sections as occupied even when no train was present. For safety reasons, signals protecting those sections then stayed red, preventing trains from operating normally. Several level crossings were also disrupted, causing problems for road traffic as well as rail passengers, but no injuries were reported.

Network impact: Passengers across central and northern Netherlands have been facing widespread cancellations, delays and longer journey times, with infrastructure manager ProRail having been removing the objects and carrying out safety checks since early morning.

Security infrastructure: The disruption lands on one of Europe's most strategically important transport systems. The Netherlands is home to Rotterdam, Europe's largest port, which would be a critical gateway for moving troops, equipment and supplies from North America and the U.K. into continental Europe in a crisis. That makes the resilience of Dutch rail and road links a military mobility issue as much as a passenger one.

Déjà vu: The disruption also comes after another major Dutch rail incident during last year's NATO summit in The Hague, when a fire caused severe delays around Schiphol airport. No one has been arrested in connection with that case.

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STATE OF THE UNION

SOTEU IS HERE: Commission President Ursula von der Leyen will kick off her State of the Union speech at 9 a.m. from Strasbourg. The speech tends to be forward-looking, laying out the Commission — and her own — agendas for the coming years. But she also likes to drop the occasional bombshell. Here's what to look for (you can also follow our live blog for the latest updates):

More trade action: In 2023, she used the SotEU to announce that the EU would launch an anti-subsidy investigation into Chinese electric vehicles, which concluded with new duties on made-in-China EVs. Now there are multiple calls across the automotive sector for the Commission to take similar action to curb the influx of Chinese plug-in hybrids. But don't expect von der Leyen to pull a similar trick this year. Rather than calling out one product, she is expected to touch on diversification measures and improving overall competitiveness.

Who is in or out: The bloc's trading partners will be closing watching the speech for any hint or announcement of who will be considered Made in Europe under the Industrial Accelerator Act. The president could give Canada a nod as being in the club, given Prime Minister Mark Carney will be in the room .

****Don't miss out on exclusive insights from the much-anticipated State of the Union speech. In our virtual briefing on Thursday, Sept. 17 at 3 p.m. BST our policy reporters break down the key issues on von der Leyen's radar, what matters most, and what it means for the coming months. Sign up now .****

MARITIME

COUNTING THE COST OF THE CRISIS: For a larger merchant ship, bypassing the Red Sea can add costs in the mid-six-figure range per voyage, the German Shipowners' Association, or VDR, told our colleague Frida Preuß.

Why the bypass is necessary: Houthi rebels aligned with Iran seized further islands in the southern Red Sea near the entrance to the strategically important Bab al-Mandab Strait, worsening the security picture for merchant shipping in the region.

Look at the map: Bab al-Mandab is the gateway to the Red Sea and, from there, the Suez Canal — the shortest sea route between Asia and Europe. For years, a significant share of global trade moved through this corridor.

High risk: Many shipping companies have already been avoiding the area because of repeated Houthi attacks on merchant vessels, rerouting instead around the Cape of Good Hope. In the meantime, however, the security situation had calmed down somewhat and there had been a "cautious return of individual ships" to the Red Sea, according to the VDR.

Major step back: "The latest developments have again undone a significant portion of the interim recovery in traffic," the association told Frida.

Unlike in the crisis in the Strait of Hormuz, ships can avoid the conflict area by using alternative routes, but that costs time and money. The journey around Africa takes about two weeks longer.

Double cost burden: "The ship travels significantly further and therefore consumes more fuel, while at the same time fuel itself has become more expensive as a result of high oil prices. Added to this are longer deployment times for the ship and crew, as well as further operating costs," VDR said.

Law of large numbers: “When thousands of ships have to travel longer distances, consume more fuel, are tied up longer, and insurance or freight rates rise, these costs add up.”

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****A message from BMW Group:** Europe’s automotive industry is entering a crucial decade. As manufacturers navigate electrification, global competition, geopolitical uncertainty and rising energy costs, Europe faces the challenge of delivering decarbonization while strengthening competitiveness and resilience. In this Q&A , POLITICO Studio speaks to Dr. Frank Niederländer, Vice President for Government Affairs Europe at BMW Group, about the choices and conditions that will shape the next phase of Europe’s automotive transition. He discusses how Europe can strengthen the industrial base behind the transition, what it will take to build a competitive battery ecosystem and why establishing new capabilities requires the right investment conditions — and time to scale. He also explores why policymakers should look beyond tailpipe emissions to consider the full value chain, and the potential role of renewable fuels alongside electrification. And why the transition will only succeed if it works for consumers and businesses while keeping investment, innovation and value creation in Europe.**

* Sponsor: BMW Group

* The advertisement is linked to the EU Automotive Package and the Industrial Accelerator Act.

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Headlines

Here’s a recap of yesterday’s news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

UN Security Council meets as Houthis tighten grip on Red Sea chokepoint

The meeting comes after the Iran-backed group seized strategic islands on the Bab el-Mandeb strait.

By Milena Wälde · Sept 15, 2026, 02:39 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

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